UX/UI Curriculum Design Principles

OVERVIEW

Designing and developing a part-time UX/UI curriculum that teaching design process to new designers.

PLATFORM

Google Docs

RESPONSIBILITIES

Establishing and getting instructor involved in the ethos and foundations in which the UX/UI curriculum was designed and developed. Includes pedagogical ideas, conceptual frameworks, and curriculum rationale.

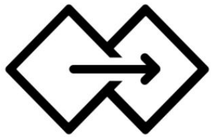
OUTCOMES

Iterated over 4 years but as new team members jointed the team they were able to quickly grasp the foundations under which the curriculum was developed.



1. Students Are Our Focus

We are a multi-disciplined human-centered design team that applies the user-centered approach to our curriculum to train human-centered designers. The students are your users. You, as the instructor, are our (the curriculum team's) user. All user experience (UX)/user interface (UI) course materials are established on this foundation so that the instructional team can extend their user-first approach throughout the 24 weeks of this program and beyond. Students are our focus. This applies to every aspect of the UX/UI Boot Camp—from the instructional staff to student support managers, to career services, and beyond. Our No Back Row® philosophy (#nobackrow) offers a program for students to reach their highest learning potential.



2. The Design Process Is the Best Design Tool

Our students have a wide range of skills coming into the UX/UI Boot Camp. Some come from a design background while others might be from the medical field. If students gain experience with the design process, they will be more productive and workplace-ready for the new roles they will fill. The design software world changes quickly, which is why executing the design process is more important than understanding any one design tool. UX/UI Boot Camp is about design as a process and not so much about which tool you use to apply that knowledge. Many different tools are used to execute the design process, and we will lean heavily on pen and paper first, graduating to software like Figma, Adobe XD, and InVision to execute digital prototyping. Design software is not a one-way street, and if students want to use Sketch or other tools to execute their prototyping process, they may.

By teaching students the process, we're empowering them to focus on more valuable skills. Give a person a tool, and they can use it in a specific context. Teach a person why a tool is needed and how it is relevant to the overall process, and they will solve problems and create great things.



3. Struggle Gives Rise to Real Learning

The boot camp learning environment is challenging by design. Learning research tells us that an unchallenged brain doesn't learn, so if students never struggle, they won't benefit from the course. Our curriculum is built to be supportive but tough so that students' minds are challenged, and they learn. We also cover a wide range of skills from UX to UI to front-end development. Being an expert at everything in a six-month boot camp is an unreasonable expectation. However, the curriculum is designed to put students on the right path and to encourage them to keep learning, even when it is hard.



4. Hands-on Practice Through Prototyping

Through the design thinking process, students are getting hands-on practice with activities using tangible materials (sticky notes, paper, whiteboards, etc.) and digital executions (Adobe XD, InVision, Slack, etc.). The curriculum also applies Designerly Ways of Knowing (DWOK) principles.
The following are highlights from Grounding IS Design Education in the First Principles of a Designerly Way of Knowing: Design is continuous. Exploring and learning to happen in a dynamic social environment (classroom) and through interactive technology. Design reconciles worldviews. Uses empathy to create human-centered solutions. The medium of construction (the web) determines the design choices (size, UI elements, etc.). Prototyping UIs designed in context to the technology and the user's needs. Humans' knowledge and conscious expression are imperfect. Failure is essential for validating a solution. User testing will help create tighter iterative cycles. The operative appreciative systems determine the whole of the design space. Stakeholders and designers apply a perception of the world through a worldview that determines what cues they notice to determine their sense of approval or displeasure. Designers must build bridges to attain cohesion between the stakeholder's needs and the user's needs.



5. Learning Through Backward Design

We have developed the UX/UI curriculum through a backward design methodology. We begin with the learning objectives of a unit and define what students are expected to learn and be able to do for their week's assignment. The lesson creation proceeds "backward" to create lesson plans, activities, discussions, and reviews that achieve those skills throughout each class and each unit.



6. UX/UI Designers Should Be "Code Conversational"

UX/UI designers are not developers, and we do not expect them to be. However, the reality is that a UX/UI designer's work ends up as code whether that be a software solution, a website, or any other user-facing interface. Our students will be joining a fast-moving profession that requires them to work alongside developers as teammates. Learning and being able to code some HTML/CSS/JavaScript will get them some experience working on human-centered code problems together. This will, in turn, prepare them to join a team and work alongside their developer colleagues to execute solutions through software prototypes.



7. Case Study–Driven UX/UI Portfolios Are Key to Student Success

The design process happens over time and is best communicated through a case study that tells a story of how a designer went from nothing to something. A UX/UI designer's value resides in how they think, and how they think is demonstrated through the deliverables that make up the design process.Out in the "real world," UX/UI designers must share their thinking, work skills, and UX/UI samples through a visual portfolio that helps highlight strengths and types of problems they are good at solving. This is typically done online. We assist our students in executing their design portfolios while allowing them to practice the design process and communicate their solutions through a series of case studies. We also prepare them for interviews that will help them get into their next role in the workplace or their career.